

CS & AI • EXPLAINED

What is **the cloud** actually?

Spoiler: it's not in the sky.

THE HOOK

“Don’t worry, it’s saved in the **cloud**.” We say it **daily**.

But the cloud isn’t floating in the sky — it’s a very real, very **physical** place.

Let’s go inside and actually see it. ☁



TODAY'S QUESTION

When something is "in the cloud",
where does it **actually** sit — and
whose computer is it?

”The cloud” = other people’s **computers**.

- These computers are called **servers**.
- You use them over the **internet**, instead of your own device.
- ”In the cloud” = sitting on a **company’s server** somewhere.

IN SHORT

There is no ”cloud”.
It’s just **computers** — far away.

Those servers live in **data centres**.



Your phone



Internet



Data centre



Server

- Huge warehouses with **thousands** of computers stacked in racks.
- Massive **cooling** + backup power, running **24/7**.
- Real places — Mumbai, Hyderabad, and all around the world.

You **rent** it — you don't buy it.

- Rent computing & storage instead of buying your own machines.
- Reach your stuff from **any device, anywhere**.
- It **scales instantly** when you need more.
- Someone else handles the hardware & maintenance.



access anywhere



scales instantly



no maintenance

Like an **OYO room** vs buying a flat — use it, pay for it, walk away.

You use it **every single day.**



Google Photos



WhatsApp backup



Netflix



Gmail

- All of these live as **files on servers** — not really on your phone.
- They **stream to you on demand** over the internet.
- "Cloud" = renting space online + reaching it from **anywhere**.

WHY IT MATTERS

Now a few things **make sense**.

- "Storage full — buy more cloud" = renting **more space** on those servers.
- No internet? You **can't reach** the cloud — your stuff is far away.
- Backups survive even if your phone breaks — the copy lives in a data centre.
- Privacy angle: your files sit on **someone else's computer**.

COMMON MYTH — "YEH GALAT SAMAJHTE HAIN"

X MYTH

"The cloud is wireless, floating in the air — some magical, infinite storage."

✓ REALITY

It's **physical servers** in big buildings, **owned by companies**, reached over the internet. Very much on the ground.

RECAP — 2 THINGS TO REMEMBER

- 1 The cloud = other people's servers in data centres, used over the internet.
- 2 You rent it — they own it and maintain it for you.

The cloud = computers you rent. 

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Next question: How does Google find answers so fast? 